

# *flea*

# NEWS 68

June 2011



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<http://esanetworks.org/>

FLEA NEWS is a biannual newsletter about fleas (Siphonaptera). Recipients are urged to check any citations given here before including them in publications. Many of our sources are abstracting journals and current literature sources such as National Agricultural Library (NAL) Agricola, and National Library of Medicine (NLM) Medline, and citations have not necessarily been checked for accuracy or consistent formatting.

Recipients are urged to contribute items of interest to the profession for inclusion herein, including: Flea research citations from journals that are not indexed in Agricola or Medline databases, Announcements and Requests for material, Contact information for a Directory of Siphonapterists (name, mailing address, email address, and areas of interest - Systematics, Ecology, Control, etc.), Abstracts of research planned or in progress, Book reviews, Biography, Hypotheses and Literature Reviews, and Anecdotes. Send to:

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## Announcements

The Ph.D. thesis of student D.M. de Avelar (student of P.M. Linardi) on *Tunga* was successfully defended on 30 June 2010: "Sistemática e análise cladística das espécies neotropicais do gênero *Tunga* Jarocki, 1838 (Siphonaptera: Tungidae)".

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New networks on the Entomological Society of America (ESA) meeting are now available, including Flea News. Anyone can register and join the networks, and you do not need to be a member of ESA. <http://esanetworks.org/>

Please contact the editor if there are questions.

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Additional information on another, similar, network (Veterinary Entomologists) is reprinted below:

“A new ESA network has been created for Veterinary Entomologists. Many of you will recall that we tried this once before under the old system of ESA networks, but for several reasons that effort was not successful. The new system is somewhat more user friendly and also has the advantage of being open to Non ESA members.

The new system works in a similar way to Face Book, those of you that are interested in joining the network will first need to go to the ESA networks sign up page and create a password, then you will be asked for some basic information to set up a profile. Once you have your profile set up you can join the network (or any of the others that look interesting to you!). Once you have joined you can use the “Invite” function to ask friends and colleagues to join, either by entering their contact information directly, or by using your address book (don’t worry, it will ask you which people from your address book you want to invite).

This Network will only be as useful as we make it, the broader the membership the more useful it will be, so sign up and invite your colleagues, and we’ll see if we can make this new tool from ESA work for us!

Glen

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PS: I am by no means an expert on this system, but it seems relatively straightforward to me. If you want to join and are having difficulty or if you have questions I'd be happy act as a liaison to the ESA staff to try and solve any problems that arise.

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The 11<sup>th</sup> International Symposium on Ectoparasites of Pets was held in conjunction with the 56<sup>th</sup> annual meeting of the American Association of Veterinary Parasitologists and the 55<sup>th</sup> annual Livestock Insect Workers Conference in St. Louis, MO, July 16-19. Over 260 people attended the joint conference. Presentations related to fleas included the following:

**#18** Prevalence of *Dipylidium caninum* and *Taenia taeniaeformis* in cats.

Chris Adolph, Susan Little, Kathryn Downie, and Tim Snider.

Department of Veterinary Pathobiology, Center for Veterinary Health Sciences,  
Oklahoma State University, Stillwater, OK.

**#37** Evaluation of the ovicidal activity of lufenuron and spinosad on fleas eggs from treated dogs.

M. Dryden, P. Payne, V. Smith, and D. Ritchie.

Department of Diagnostic Medicine/Pathobiology, Kansas State University,  
Manhattan, KS.

**#38** A field assessment of FRONTLINE® Plus (fipronil/(S)-methoprene) for the control of flea populations in heavily flea infested private residences and on naturally infested pets in Tampa FL, 10 years after introduction.

Michael W. Dryden, Doug S. Carithers, Amy L. McBride, Breanne M. Riggs, Lindsey Smith, Jacob M. Davenport, Vicki E. Smith, Patricia A. Payne, and Sheila J. Gross.

Kansas State University, Manhattan, KS, and Merial Limited, Duluth, GA, and  
Independent Statistician, Piscataway, NJ.

**#39** Efficacy of the Scalibor® Protector Band (4% w/w deltamethrin-impregnated collar) for the control of *Amblyomma americanum* and *Ctenocephalides felis* infestations on dogs.

Tariq Qureshi, J. Alexander Hair, Fangshi Sun, and Frank Guerino.

Intervet/Schering-Plough Animal Health, Summit NJ, and Nu-Era farms,  
Stillwater, OK.

**#55** Overview of dose confirmation and non-interference studies to assess the oral efficacy of a combination of milbemycin oxime and spinosad against the two dose-limiting parasites, adult cat flea (*Ctenocephalides felis*) and adult hookworm (*Ancylostoma caninum*), in dogs.

Daniel E Snyder and Scott Wiseman.  
 Elanco Animal Health, Greenfield, IN, and Eli Lilly and Company Ltd.,  
 Basingstoke, U.K.

Merial introduced Certifect for dogs (containing fipronil, methoprene, and amitraz).

Elanco provided information on Trifexis (spinosad + milbemycin oxime) for dogs, Comfortis (spinosad) for dogs, and Assurity (spinetoram) for cats.

Copies of the **Proceedings** are available (at cost) from Dr. Bob Arther  
 ([Bob.Arther@Bayer.com](mailto:Bob.Arther@Bayer.com)).

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### Meetings

The 66th International Conference on Diseases in Nature Communicable to Man (INCDNCM),  
 July 24-26, 2011, Northern Arizona University, Flagstaff, Arizona.  
<http://sites.google.com/site/incdncm/Home>

International Ethological Conference and the Animal Behavior Society, July 25-30, 2011,  
 Indiana University, Bloomington, Indiana.

The Tropical Disease International Actualization Forum, July 27-28, Hotel Irotama, Santa Marta,  
 Columbia.

Hennig XXX, July 29 - August 2, 2011, São Paulo, Brazil.

The 82nd Rocky Mountain Conference of Entomologists, July 31-August 3, 2011, Cathedral  
 Ridge Conference & Retreat Centre in Woodland Park, Colorado.

Royal Entomological Society's Annual National Meeting, September 7-9, 2011, Natural  
 Resources Institute, University of Greenwich, Medway Campus, Chatham Maritime, Kent.

Seventh International Conference on Arthropods, September 18-23, 2011, Białka Tatrzańska  
 near Zakopane, Poland.

SOVE Annual Conference, Sep. 25-29th, 2011, Flagstaff, Arizona,  
[http://www.sove.org/Society\\_for\\_Vector\\_Ecology/Home.html](http://www.sove.org/Society_for_Vector_Ecology/Home.html)

Wildlife Disease Association, Australasian Section Annual Conference, 25th -30th September,  
 2011, Camp Coorong, South Australia.

The 54th Annual American Association of Veterinary Laboratory Diagnosticians (AAVLD)/  
 United States Animal Health Association (USAHA) Annual Meeting, September 29 - October 5,  
 2011, Buffalo Adam's Mark Hotel, Buffalo, NY.

The 6th European Meeting on Viral Zoonoses, October 1-4, 2011, St. Raphaël, France.

The Sixth International Symposium on Molecular Insect Science, October 2-5, 2011, Amsterdam, Holland.

The 30th World Veterinary Congress, 10-14 October, 2011, Cape Town, South Africa.

Entomological Society of British Columbia, October 14th - 15th 2011, University of the Fraser Valley, Abbotsford, BC.

The 5th Asian Workshop on Zoo and Wildlife Medicine, Conservation in Nepal 2011, October 20 – 23, 2011, Kathmandu, Nepal.

American Association of Zoo Veterinarians Annual Conference, October 23-28th, 2011, Kansas City, Missouri, USA.

Wildlife Society 18th Annual Conference, November 5-10, 2011, Waikoloa, Hawaii.

Entomological Society of Canada and the Acadian Entomological Society, November 6–9, 2011, Westin Nova Scotian Hotel, Halifax, Nova Scotia, Canada.

The Second World Conference on Biological Invasions and Ecosystem Functioning, Mar del Plata, Argentina, November 21-24, 2011.

Entomological Society of America (ESA), November 13-16, 2011, Reno-Sparks Convention Center, Reno, Nevada.

Midwest Fish and Wildlife Conference, December 4-7, 2011, Des Moines, Iowa.

The Sixth International Conference on Biopesticides, December 11-16, 2011, Chiangmai, Thailand.

The Second International Symposium of Bio-Pesticides and Eco-toxicological Network, March 1-3, 2012, Bangkok, Thailand.

ESA Southeastern and Southwestern Branches, March 3-8, 2012, Peabody Hotel, Little Rock, Arkansas.

ESA Eastern Branch Meeting, March 16-19, 2012, Hilton, Hartford, Connecticut.

ESA Pacific Branch Meeting, March 24-28, 2012, Portland Waterfront Marriott, Portland, Oregon.

The 7th International IPM Symposium, March 27-29, 2012, Memphis Cook Convention Center, Memphis, Tennessee.

Southwestern Association of Naturalists, 19-22 April 2012, Universidad Autónoma de Estado de México, Valle de Bravo, México.

ESA North Central Branch Meeting, June 3-6, 2012, Embassy Suites, Lincoln, Nebraska.

Tim Lysyk (Lethbridge Research Centre, Alberta, Canada; Tim.Lysyk@agr.gc.ca) announced that he and Greg Johnson (Montana State Univ., gdj@montana.edu) would be co-hosting the 2012 Livestock Insect Workers Conference in Kalispell, Montana. Dates are June 24-27, 2012 and the meeting will be held at the Red Lion Inn in Kalispell.

The 12th International Symposium on Ectoparasites of Pets will be held in Munich, Germany, April 7-10, 2013, hosted by Dr. Klaus Hellmann (Klifovent AG) and Prof. Kurt Pfister (University of Munich). To be added to the e-mail list to be notified of meeting events, please send your e-mail address to Dr. Bill Donahue of Sierra Research Labs (SRL@clearwire.net).

Additional meetings calendar at: <http://wildlifedisease.nbi.gov/c&aevents.jsp>

### Featured Research

de Avelar, Daniel M ; Linardi, Pedro M ; Linardi, P. M. . Use of Multiple Displacement Amplification as Pre-polymerase Chain Reaction (Pre-PCR) to amplify genomic DNA of siphonapterids preserved for long periods in scientific collections. *Parasites & Vectors*, v. 3, p. 86, 2010.

de Avelar, D. M.; MELO, M. N.; LINARDI, P. M. 2011. Morphology and growth characteristics of cultured *Leptomonas ctenocephali* from *Ctenocephalides felis felis* (Siphonaptera: Pulicidae) of dogs in Brazil. *Veterinary Parasitology* published on-line: doi:10.1016/j.vetpar.2011.03.028),

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Dykstra, Thomas Matthew. 1997. A BEHAVIORAL AND PERCEPTUAL STUDY OF CAT FLEA LARVAE, *Ctenocephalides felis*, AND THEIR RESPONSES TO VARIOUS STIMULI. University of Florida Dissertation, Doctor of Philosophy. Chairman: Dr. Philip S. Callahan.

### ABSTRACT

Cat flea larvae, *Ctenocephalides felis*, were found to exhibit an orientation response toward a human stimulus. This is the first report describing this behavior in the cat flea larva. The response was first observed and tested throughout this study in a covered plastic petri dish, and was determined to occur over relatively short distances of up to 2 meters from a human being sitting in a chair. The orientation response could be enhanced by increasing the numbers of cat flea larvae in an experiment.

Cat flea larvae were additionally found to react to magnetic fields of approximately 750 Gauss and electric field intensities of  $4.1 \times 10^{-3}$  V/m, which were discovered to alter the

orientation response if tested in conjunction with a human stimulus. The presence of two types of magnets when placed between the fleas and the human stimulus adversely affected the orientation response, which resulted in random movement about the petri dish. The same result was achieved with wind produced from a small fan positioned so as to pass air across the surface of the petri dish. Random behavior, or non-directional movement, was additionally noted when the flea larvae were placed above head level. Cat flea larvae could locate and orient to a human stimulus below head level, but the response was reduced at much lower levels such as ground level.

The cause of this orientation response may be mediated in part or in whole by electromagnetic frequencies of unknown origin. This possibility was theoretically analyzed in reference to external larval morphology. The cat flea's body as well as two of its components, the antenna and the body setae, are certainly capable of receiving complex electromagnetic messages. Detection of electromagnetic radiation may be operating individually or in concert. The possible occurrence of electromagnetic field detection for an insect is discussed with an extensive literature review outlining possible mechanisms.

Thomas M. Dykstra. 2003. Cat flea larvae, *Ctenocephalides felis*, exhibit a strong taxis response to a human stimulus. (Abstract, Presentation at the 2003 ESA Annual Meeting and Exhibition, Cincinnati, OH. [http://esa.confex.com/esa/2003/techprogram/paper\\_12540.htm](http://esa.confex.com/esa/2003/techprogram/paper_12540.htm)).

Pilot studies showed that groups of 100 cat flea larvae or more before the wandering stage would form tight clusters in a petri dish. These clusters would form in a few minutes and then exhibit a taxis response, en masse, in the direction of a human stimulus. This response only occurred when the larvae were placed at or below the height of a human stimulus. The taxis response would progress in 10-20 minutes and would remain for hours unless disturbed. Repeating the experiments with from one to ten larvae revealed that the taxis response was assisted by group dynamics but did not require it. Statistical analysis showed that the degree of orientation was accurate to within 40 degrees which was the experiment's maximum resolution. The taxis response is hypothesized to be a generalized response to the host animal.

(Editor's note: molecular versus electromagnetic perception in insects is a continuing controversy in entomology. Extensive research involves the honeybees' odor search and their perception of electromagnetic fields and resulting bee dances (Wenner, A. M. and Wells, P. H. 1990. Anatomy of a controversy: the question of a "language" among bees. – Columbia Univ. Press, New York). The question is: are molecules sensed directly when they fit, as a lock and key, into sensory molecules in the epithelia of insect antennae? Alternatively, are molecules sensed indirectly by emitted radiation which is received by insect antennae acting as electromagnetic receivers? Or, in what manner are both modes employed by insects?)

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Haas, Glenn E., N. Wilson, J.R. Kucera, T.O. Osborne, J.S. Whitman, and W.N. Johnson. 2010. Range expansion and hosts of *Ctenophthalmus pseudagyrtes* Baker (Siphonaptera: Ctenophthalmidae) in central Alaska. J. Entomol. Soc. Brit. Columbia 107:87-88.

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Haas, Glenn E., and James R. Kucera. 2010. Shrew Flea, *Corrodopsylla curvata*, in Nest and Range Extension in New Mexico with Review of Relevant Records in Six Western States. *Southwestern Entomologist* 35(4):525-532.

The shrew flea, *Corrodopsylla curvata curvata* (Rothschild, 1915) (Siphonaptera: Ctenophthalmidae), is not common in collections of fleas from the Southwest or Rocky Mountains. Fewer records are from nests than trapped hosts. In 1993, a live female specimen was found in a nest that belonged to an unknown small mammal in the southern Sangre de Cristo Mountains of New Mexico. A 67-km extension of range was measured from the nearest of four trap sites in the Jemez Mountains, Sandoval County. The nest site was east-southeast across the Rio Grande in Dalton Canyon, Pecos River watershed, San Miguel County. The nest, its contents, and habitat were described. In addition, we reviewed nonpublished ecological data from each of the three collections from trapped hosts in the Jemez Mountains, 1970-1971, and provided a distribution map. A review of records of *C. c. curvata* and *C. c. obtusata* (Wagner, 1929) in western mountains with emphasis on small samples from a canyon in Montana suggested that larger samples would confirm the absence of a zone of intergradation between two allopatric species.

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Lareschi, M. and B. Krasnov. 2010. Determinants of ectoparasite assemblage structure on rodent hosts from South American marshland: The effects of host species, locality and season. *Medical and Veterinary Entomology* 24: 284-292.

Lareschi M, Autino, MM Diaz, R Barquez. 2011. Taxonomy and Distribution of *Nonnapsylla* Wagner, 1938 (Siphonaptera, Stephanocircidae, Craneopsyllinae). *Journal of Parasitology* (in press).

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Linardi, P. M. . Checklist de Siphonaptera (Insecta) do Estado de São Paulo. *Biota Neotropica* (Edição em Português. Online), v. 11, p. bn0301101a, 2011.

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Maher, Sean P. 2010. SPATIAL DYNAMICS OF MAMMALS AND THEIR PATHOGENS AND PARASITES. University of Kansas in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of Dissertation, Doctor of Philosophy.  
<http://hdl.handle.net/1808/6446>

## ABSTRACT

In this dissertation, I explore several aspects of the ecological dynamics of mammals and



their pathogens and parasites. I approach this broad topic at various scales, using Ecological Niche Models, field surveys, and theoretical simulations. I focus on two pathogens, hantavirus and plague (*Yersinia pestis*), and a group of parasites, fleas, and address their spatial and ecological relationships. Each of the four chapters presents a set of questions and tests hypotheses regarding the distribution of these taxa. I begin by demonstrating that plague-infected host distributions are not similar to the non-infected host distributions, suggesting that vector ecology may drive the distribution of plague in the western United States. I then show that hantavirus prevalence and flea communities are not mediated by mammalian communities across a contiguous landscape, and flea communities differ with increasing elevation. Finally, I show that re-appearance of hantavirus after a decline in host populations likely is not driven by metapopulation dynamics.

Maher SP, Ellis C, Gage KL, Ensore RE, Peterson AT. 2010. Range-wide determinants of plague distribution in North America. *Am J Trop Med Hyg.* 83(4): 736-42.

Plague, caused by the bacterium *Yersinia pestis*, is established across western North America, and yet little is known of what determines the broad-scale dimensions of its overall range. We tested whether its North American distribution represents a composite of individual host-plague associations (the "Host Niche Hypothesis"), or whether mammal hosts become infected only at sites overlapping ecological conditions appropriate for plague transmission and maintenance (the "Plague Niche Hypothesis"). We took advantage of a novel data set summarizing plague records in wild mammals newly digitized from paper-based records at the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention to develop range-wide tests of ecological niche similarity between mammal host niches and plague-infected host niches. Results indicate that plague infections occur under circumstances distinct from the broader ecological distribution of hosts, and that plague-infected niches are similar among hosts; hence, evidence coincides with the predictions of the Plague Niche Hypothesis, and contrasts with those of the Host Niche Hypothesis. The "plague niche" is likely driven by ecological requirements of vector flea species.

Steven J. Taylor, Jean K. Krejca, and Michael E. Slay. 2008. Cave Biota of Great Basin National Park, White Pine County, Nevada. Illinois Natural History Survey Technical Report 2008 (25), prepared for Great Basin National Park, Baker, Nevada.

"Fleas were recorded from three caves, across a wide range of elevations (1724-3013 meters [5656-9885 feet]). These are ectoparasites, and are probably associated with packrats or other rodents." [Editor's Note: Bat fleas may occur in caves with bats.] "The fleas were taken from damp silt or under rocks on soil in twilight." [pg 336]. "Collembola, Diptera, and Spiders were the most abundant taxa. The cave was also notable for the large variety of vertebrate remains found below the entrance drop. The rate of vertebrate accumulation in the cave appears to be fairly high. The cave also contained more bats than most of the caves examined during this study." [pg 28] Little Muddy Cave had no fleas listed in 2008 report, but in 2003 report had fleas. [pg 273] "Several dead bats were recorded from the floor of a low elevation cave on dry to normal breakdown or soil floors." [pg 345] The "bat *Corynorhinus townsendii pallascens* (Chiroptera: Vespertilionidae) also has been observed in this cave" (Long Cold Cave). [pg 26] *Myotis evotis evotis* (Chiroptera, Vespertilionidae) were in several caves. [pg 157]. Siphonaptera

[(not further identified)] were in 3 of 24 caves, but not in Lehman Cave. [pg 155] (Editor's abstract)

<http://www.nps.gov/grba/naturescience/cave-life.htm>

Jean K. Krejca and Steven J. Taylor 2003. Final Report. A biological inventory of eight caves in Great Basin National Park.

(Center for Biodiversity, Illinois Natural History Survey, 607 East Peabody Drive, Champaign, Illinois, 61820, [sjtaylor@inhs.uiuc.edu](mailto:sjtaylor@inhs.uiuc.edu)).

Order Siphonaptera, Undetermined (Little Muddy Cave), Family Dolichophysillidae (Desert Research Institute 1968), from Lehman Cave, [Desert Research Institute. 1968. Final reports on the Lehman Caves studies to the Department of the Interior, National Park Service, Lehman Caves National Monument. The Laboratory of Desert Biology, Desert Research Institute, Reno, Nevada. 57 pp.] (Editor's abstract)

### Recent highly cited papers on fleas

Baer, R., W. Turnberg, D. Yu, and R. Wohrle. 2010. Leptospirosis in a small animal veterinarian: Reminder to follow standardized infection control procedures. *Zoonoses and Public Health* 57, (4): 281-284.

Barrs, V. R., J. A. Beatty, B. J. Wilson, N. Evans, R. Gowan, R. M. Baral, A. E. Lingard, G. Perkovic, J. R. Hawley, and M. R. Lappin. 2010. Prevalence of *Bartonella* species, *Rickettsia felis*, *Haemoplasmas* and the *Ehrlichia* group in the blood of cats and fleas in eastern Australia. *Australian Veterinary Journal* 88, (5): 160-165.

Breitschwerdt, E. B., R. G. Maggi, B. B. Chomel, and M. R. Lappin. 2010. Bartonellosis: An emerging infectious disease of zoonotic importance to animals and human beings. *Journal of Veterinary Emergency and Critical Care* 20, (1): 8-30.

Brinkerhoff, R. J., H. Kabeya, K. Inoue, Y. Bai, and S. Maruyama. 2010. Detection of multiple *Bartonella* species in digestive and reproductive tissues of fleas collected from sympatric mammals. *ISME Journal* 4, (7): 955-958.

Chomel, B. B., and R. W. Kasten. 2010. Bartonellosis, an increasingly recognized zoonosis. *Journal of applied microbiology* 109, (3): 743-750.

Dietrich, F., T. Schmidgen, R. G. Maggi, D. Richter, F. -R Matuschka, R. Vonthein, E. B. Breitschwerdt, and V. A. J. Kempf. 2010. Prevalence of *Bartonella henselae* and *Borrelia burgdorferi* sensu lato DNA in *Ixodes ricinus* ticks in Europe. *Applied and Environmental Microbiology* 76, (5): 1395-1398.

Goodyer, L. I., A. M. Croft, S. P. Frances, N. Hill, S. J. Moore, S. P. Onyango, and M. Debboun. 2010. Expert review of the evidence base for arthropod bite avoidance. *Journal of Travel Medicine* 17, (3): 182-192.

Guptill, L. 2010. Bartonellosis. *Veterinary microbiology* 140, (3-4): 347-359.

Longhorn, S. J., H. W. Pohl, and A. P. Vogler. 2010. Ribosomal protein genes of holometabolan insects reject the Halteria, instead revealing a close affinity of Strepsiptera with Coleoptera. *Molecular phylogenetics and evolution* 55, (3): 846-859.

Olivry, T., D. J. DeBoer, C. Favrot, H. A. Jackson, R. S. Mueller, T. Nuttall, and P. Pr  laud. 2010. Treatment of canine atopic dermatitis: 2010 clinical practice guidelines from the international task force on canine atopic dermatitis. *Veterinary dermatology* 21, (3): 233-248.

Otranto, D., and F. Dantas-Torres. 2010. Fleas and ticks as vectors of *Leishmania* spp. to dogs: Caution is needed. *Veterinary parasitology* 168, (1-2): 173-174.

Otranto, D., D. de Caprariis, R. P. Lia, V. Tarallo, V. Lorusso, G. Testini, F. Dantas-Torres, et al. 2010. Prevention of endemic canine vector-borne diseases using imidacloprid 10% and permethrin 50% in young dogs: A longitudinal field study. *Veterinary parasitology* 172, (3-4): 323-332.

Paz, G. F., M. F. B. Ribeiro, D. F. de Magalh  es, K. P. B. Sathler, M. H. F. Morais, V. O. P. Fi  za, S. T. Brand  o, G. L. Werneck, C. L. Fortes-Dias, and E. S. Dias. 2010. Association between the prevalence of infestation by *Rhipicephalus sanguineus* and *Ctenocephalides felis felis* and the presence of anti-leishmania antibodies: A case-control study in dogs from a Brazilian endemic area. *Preventive veterinary medicine* 97, (2): 131-133.

Salkeld, D. J., M. Salath  , P. Stapp, and J. H. Jones. 2010. Plague outbreaks in prairie dog populations explained by percolation thresholds of alternate host abundance. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences of the United States of America* 107, (32): 14247-14250.

Telford III, S. R., and G. P. Wormser. 2010. *Bartonella* spp. transmission by ticks not established. *Emerging Infectious Diseases* 16, (3): 379-384.

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### Directory of Siphonapterists (updated)

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